

Moorland and heath

In cool, wet, hilly regions made up of hard rock such as granite, the wild landscape is often dominated by heather moors and acidic peat bogs. These bleak moorlands resemble the lowland heaths that form on infertile, sandy, or stony soils in milder climates. Other types of heath develop in warmer regions where the climate is too arid or dry for trees.

COLD RAIN

Rugged uplands are often made of hard rock covered with thin, acidic soil. In cool oceanic regions, heavy rain washes soluble plant nutrients out of the soil, so only a few types of tough, low-growing plants can survive. They cover huge areas, creating bleak moorland with few trees.

▼ HEATHER MOOR

Purple-flowering heather makes a splash of color beneath the rain-swept skies of Glencoe in the Scottish Highlands.



DARK PEAT

Waterlogged moorland is taken over by sphagnum moss, which soaks up the water like a sponge. As the moss dies off, it does not decay, but builds up in thick layers of peat. On the wet uplands, this process forms blanket bogs that cover vast areas of the landscape, dotted with dark bog pools that swarm with mosquitoes in summer.